Westerners endeavoured to understand Indian gymnosophy and related philosophical directions and were amazed by social habits such as offering the dead to vultures. But these observers, Marshall laments, had nothing to say ‘about the appearance of the city, the houses of the people, or the countless other things that an archaeologist wants to know concerning material culture.’[15] Consequently we know nothing either about the city’s governance by Mauryan officials which the Taxilans were supposedly rebelling against.

Luckily there is a welter of ruins—walls and wells, shops and squares, and much else—from which the lives of the citizenry can be reconstructed. Leading a contingent of men and animals, Ashoka will have sighted Taxila from a distance, standing as it did on a plateau which rose between 18 and 21 metres above the surrounding plains. The royal party will have seen a crowded congeries of structures covering virtually the whole of the Bhir plateau, which measures some 1097 metres north to south and around 668 metres east to west, as does the city atop it.[16] Size-wise Taxila was far smaller than some of the other great cities of Ashoka’s time, but not many were located on a natural promontory visible from a distance. Taxila, Ashoka may well have thought, was in this respect a little like Champa—the place from where Ashoka’s mother possibly hailed—in ancient Bihar, a very old town on a tableland, seen before it is reached, and not far from Pataliputra.

As the army reached Taxila’s immediate surroundings the variable elevations that made up the skyline of the city would have become visible. Its flat-roofed houses were likely to have been of varying heights, the surface of the plateau being uneven and the rubble of earlier construction lying buried under them.[17] The houses were plastered with clay, this clay-clad appearance of the city being much the same as when the first settlement was established there in the sixth century BCE. That earliest settlement was substantially smaller than the cities that grew over it, but its